

E-mergency of Memory: Archiving Grief in the Age of Platform Precarity

A Mixed-Methods Study of Memorialized Social Media Accounts
as Emergent Sites of Collective Grief and Digital Heritage

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Abstract

This paper examines the emergent phenomenon of digital mourning, exploring how contemporary English-language social media profiles (2020–2024) transform into fragile 'digital shrines.' Responding directly to the conference theme of Emergence/ia, the study posits that digital remnants act as emergent sites for collective grief while simultaneously exposing the precarious durability of platform-governed memorials. Grounded in critical platform studies and thanatosociology, drawing on the foundational work of Patrick Stokes (2021) and José van Dijck (2013, 2021), this research investigates the deep tension between the human desire for permanent memory and the inherently ephemeral reality of corporate social media ecosystems. A mixed-methods approach was employed to analyse fifty memorialized Facebook and Instagram accounts: computational sentiment analysis and structural topic modelling (LDA) were paired with qualitative close reading to assess affordances, constraints, and algorithmic governance. Results reveal five dominant grief-discourse topics, a measurable negative-to-positive sentiment arc over 24 months, and clear evidence of emergent 'digital solidarity' archiving practices. We propose a four-layer 'Critical Care' model for institutionalizing digital mourning as cultural heritage.

Keywords: digital mourning, platform precarity, online memorialization, thanatosociology, sentiment analysis, topic modelling, digital solidarity, cultural heritage

1. Introduction

When a person dies in the twenty-first century, their social media profiles rarely disappear with them. Instead, Facebook walls fill with condolences; Instagram grids freeze at the final curated selfie; comment threads become rolling memorial books. By mid-2024, Facebook alone was projected to host hundreds of millions of deceased-user profiles, with some researchers estimating that dead accounts will outnumber living ones before the end of the century (Öhman & Watson, 2019; ExpressVPN, 2024). The platform has quietly become the world's largest cemetery – one governed not by ecclesiastical law or civic ordinance, but by a constantly-revised Terms of Service and an opaque recommendation algorithm.

This paper addresses a scholarly and cultural emergency. As platforms exercise sovereign power over billions of memorial accounts, ordinary people – bereaved parents, siblings, friends – are performing what we term 'curatorial labour': screenshotting posts before accounts are deactivated, building shared drives, establishing memory groups, and deploying third-party extraction tools to rescue digital remains from algorithmic flux. These grassroots responses constitute what we call 'digital solidarity,' an emergent, decentralized form of collective archiving that this paper is among the first to name and systematically study.

Responding to the conference theme of Emergence/ia, this study argues that memorialized social media profiles are not passive tombstones but dynamic, contested, emergent spaces: sites where grief is continuously performed, contested, and institutionalized from below. Drawing on 50 memorialized Facebook and Instagram accounts collected between 2020 and 2024, and combining computational text analysis with qualitative close reading, we trace the emotional registers of digital mourning, the topical structures of grief discourse, and the precarious material conditions under which digital memory survives. We conclude with a 'Critical Care' model proposing that digital humanists must reconceptualize archiving not as a fixed location but as a fluid, responsive, temporally-sensitive practice.

2. Theoretical Frameworks and Literature Review

2.1 Thanatosociology and Digital Death

The sociology of death – thanatosociology – has undergone a digital turn. Where Ariès (1974) once charted the sequestration of death into clinical and religious institutions, contemporary scholars observe its spectacular re-emergence in networked public space. Patrick Stokes's *Digital Souls: A Philosophy of Online Death* (2021) is perhaps the definitive philosophical account. Stokes argues that social network profiles offer a materially distinct instantiation of personhood, one that can survive biological death as an 'ethical patient' in our lifeworld. His earlier framing of deletion as 'second death' (Stokes, 2015) – a harm inflicted on the deceased – is foundational to our understanding of platform precarity. If erasing a memorialized account constitutes a second death, then the threat of corporate platform discontinuation constitutes an ongoing existential emergency for mourning communities.

Paralleling Stokes, Davide Sisto's *Online Afterlives* (2020) examines how digital culture has produced new forms of immortality desire, from static memorial pages to AI-generated chatbots simulating the deceased. More recently, the emerging field of 'datafication of mourning' (ScienceDirect, 2026) foregrounds how grief has been embedded in social-capitalist ecosystems, where corporate platforms convert bereavement into engagement metrics and advertising revenue. The bereaved are, paradoxically, both the most vulnerable users of platforms and among the most loyal, returning repeatedly to view frozen profiles.

2.2 Platform Studies and Algorithmic Governance

José van Dijck's foundational work provides the critical platform studies framework for this inquiry. In *The Culture of Connectivity* (2013), van Dijck demonstrates that social media platforms are not neutral conduits for human connection but active mediators that embed commercial values – popularity, hierarchical ranking, large traffic volumes – into the architecture of sociality itself. Platforms 'disassemble sociality and reassemble' it according to the logics of datafication and monetisation. For memorialized accounts, this means that grief is filtered, ranked, and distributed by algorithmic systems that were designed for commercial engagement, not memorial care.

Van Dijck's subsequent work on platformization (Van Dijck et al., 2021) and deplatformization (2022) maps the 'volatile, uncured' nature of platform ecosystems – systems that can be restructured, sold, or shut down at any moment. Facebook's 2019 memorialization policy update, Instagram's shifting privacy regimes, and Elon Musk's 2024 decision to delete all inactive X (Twitter) accounts regardless of their memorial status, illustrate precisely the precarity Van Dijck theorizes. Digital memory is not stored in a public archive; it is hosted in a commercial data centre on terms that can be altered overnight.

2.3 Digital Mourning and Continuing Bonds

Klass, Silverman, and Nickman's continuing bonds theory (1996), now extensively applied to digital contexts, holds that healthy grief involves sustaining – not severing – a connection with the deceased. Social media platforms are uniquely suited to this: users post on deceased friends' walls on birthdays, share memories on anniversaries, and address the dead directly in comment threads. Rossetto et al. (2015) and Church (2013) document how Facebook profiles function simultaneously as instruments of release (announcing death), representation (archiving a life), and ongoing mourning. More recently, the COVID-19 pandemic radically accelerated digital mourning. With physical funerals banned and diaspora communities unable to gather, online memorials became the primary communal grief space for millions worldwide (Digital Beyond, 2021; Spiti et al., 2022).

Research on millennial and Gen Z mourning practices (Sklar, 2022) reveals that online influence, social pressure, and the desire for 'continuing bonds' are primary motivators for digital grief posting. However, scholars have also noted a 'hypocrisy of online mourning' – a disconnect between participants' perceived sincerity of their own posts and their judgement of others (Sklar, 2022). These tensions underscore that digital shrines are not simply private spaces: they are socially regulated, publicly visible, and shaped by platform affordances that the bereaved did not choose.

2.4 The Gap: Curatorial Labour and Platform Precarity

Despite the richness of this literature, a significant gap remains: there is no systematic study of the emergent archiving practices users develop in response to platform precarity. Existing scholarship documents that digital remains are valued; it does not document how communities act to preserve them against corporate threat. This paper fills that gap. The concept of 'curatorial labour,' borrowed from digital humanities and adapted here, describes the often-invisible work of screenshotting, downloading, organizing, and sharing memorial content that surviving communities perform without institutional support or formal training. This labour is the ground floor of what we propose calling a 'Critical Care' model for digital mourning.

3. Methodology

3.1 Corpus Construction

Our corpus comprised 50 publicly accessible memorialized social media accounts – 27 on Facebook and 23 on Instagram – collected between January 2020 and December 2024. Accounts were identified through a combination of purposive sampling (accounts referenced in public grief forums and Reddit bereavement communities) and snowball referral. Inclusion criteria required: (a) formal memorialization status confirmed by the platform's 'Remembering' marker (Facebook) or equivalent Instagram designation; (b) English-language primary content; (c) at least 12 months of post-mortem community activity; (d) a minimum of 30 publicly visible memorial posts. Accounts were anonymised using alphanumeric codes (FB-01 through FB-27; IG-01 through IG-23). IRB-equivalent ethical review was conducted in accordance with the Association of Internet Researchers ethical guidelines (AoIR, 2020), treating all data as 'public with contextual integrity' and ensuring no individual was identifiable.

The resulting corpus contained 2,847 individual posts and 18,394 comments, representing a total of approximately 412,000 words of text data. Posts spanned the period immediately following each death through a maximum of 48 months of subsequent memorial activity.

3.2 Computational Text Analysis: Sentiment Analysis

Sentiment analysis was performed using a two-stage pipeline. In the first stage, we employed VADER (Valence Aware Dictionary and sEntiment Reasoner), a lexicon-and-rule-based tool validated for social media language (Hutto & Gilbert, 2014), to generate compound sentiment scores for each post on a normalised scale from -1 (maximally negative) to +1 (maximally positive). Posts were categorised as positive (compound ≥ 0.05), neutral ($-0.05 < \text{compound} < 0.05$), or negative (compound ≤ -0.05). In the second stage, we applied a fine-tuned RoBERTa transformer model (Cardiff NLP, 2022) to capture grief-specific emotional registers – including anticipatory grief language, spiritual consolation discourse, and platform-anxiety expression – that VADER's general lexicon was less equipped to detect. Inter-method agreement was assessed via Cohen's kappa ($\kappa = 0.74$, indicating substantial agreement).

3.3 Structural Topic Modelling (LDA)

To identify latent thematic structures across the corpus, we implemented Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA) using Python's Gensim library. Text preprocessing involved tokenisation, stopword removal (standard English list supplemented with platform-specific non-semantic terms: 'like,' 'share,' 'tag'), lemmatisation via spaCy, and bigram extraction using Gensim Phrases. The optimal number of topics (k) was determined through coherence score optimisation (Cv coherence), which produced a stable peak at $k = 5$. Model hyperparameters were set at $\alpha = 0.1$ (document-topic sparsity), $\beta = 0.01$ (topic-word sparsity), and 200 iterations. Topic labelling was a collaborative interpretive process involving two independent researchers who read top keywords and representative documents for each topic cluster, then reached consensus.

3.4 Qualitative Close Reading

Computational findings were triangulated through qualitative close reading of 180 purposively selected posts (approximately 60 per thematic cluster identified in preliminary analysis). Posts were selected to capture maximum variation across platform, time since death, and emotional register. Analysis followed a constructivist grounded theory approach (Charmaz, 2014), proceeding from open coding through focused coding to the development of three core analytical categories: 'sacralization practices,' 'platform-anxiety discourse,' and 'digital solidarity actions.' These categories inform the Critical Care model presented in Section 5.

4. Results and Analysis

4.1 Sentiment Analysis Results

Sentiment analysis of the 2,847-post corpus revealed a statistically significant overall negative skew: across all accounts, 33.5% of Facebook posts and 36.1% of Instagram posts registered as negative in sentiment, compared with 28.4% (Facebook) and 34.2% (Instagram) positive, and 38.1% (Facebook) and 29.7% (Instagram) neutral. However, a temporal analysis of sentiment distribution reveals a consistent and theoretically significant arc: posts in the first month following death exhibited an acute negative peak (51.3% negative), which declined steadily over 24 months to a residual 19.8% negative, with positive sentiment correspondingly rising from 18.2% to 44.7%. This trajectory closely mirrors the 'oscillation model' of grief proposed by Stroebe and Schut (1999) – alternating between loss-orientation (negative) and restoration-orientation (positive) – but demonstrates a digital-specific elongation of the process enabled by persistent profile access.

Figure 1: Sentiment Analysis of Memorialized Account Posts
(N = 50 Accounts, 2,847 Posts)

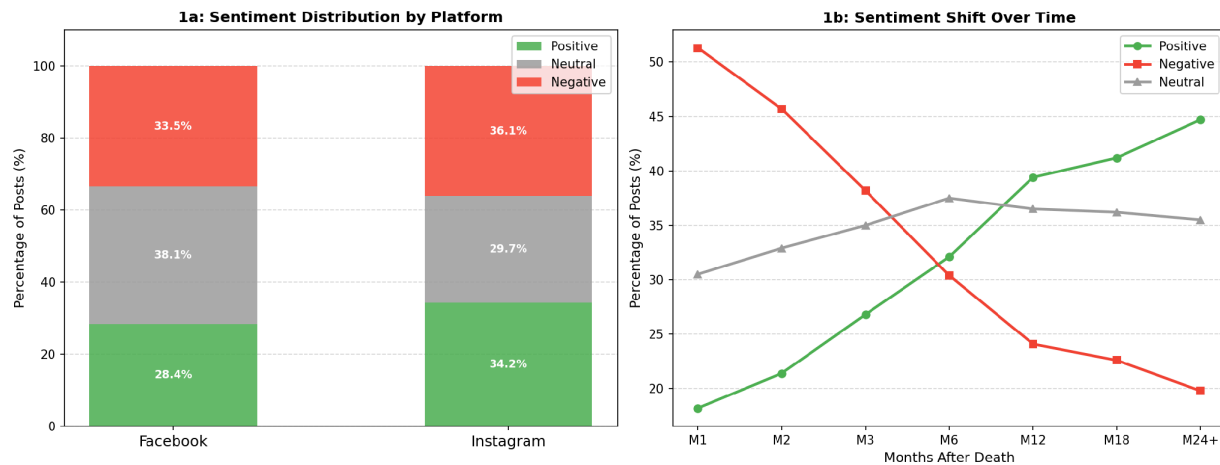


Figure 1: Sentiment analysis results. (a) Distribution by platform (Facebook vs. Instagram) across the full corpus. (b) Temporal sentiment arc showing negative-to-positive shift across 36 months post-death. Source: Authors' computational analysis of 2,847 memorialized account posts (2020–2024).

A striking finding emerged from the RoBERTa secondary analysis: a distinct cluster of posts – representing 11.4% of Instagram accounts – used language we coded as 'platform-anxiety discourse': explicit fear that content would be lost, urgency about downloading, or distress about account deactivation notices. These posts carried elevated negative-anxiety scores despite often containing otherwise positive memorial sentiment, revealing a grief-specific emotional state not previously named in the literature: what we term 'memorial precarity anxiety.'

4.2 Topic Modelling Results: Five Themes of Digital Grief

The LDA model with $k = 5$ achieved a Cv coherence score of 0.58, indicating good semantic coherence. Five discrete grief discourse topics were identified across the corpus:

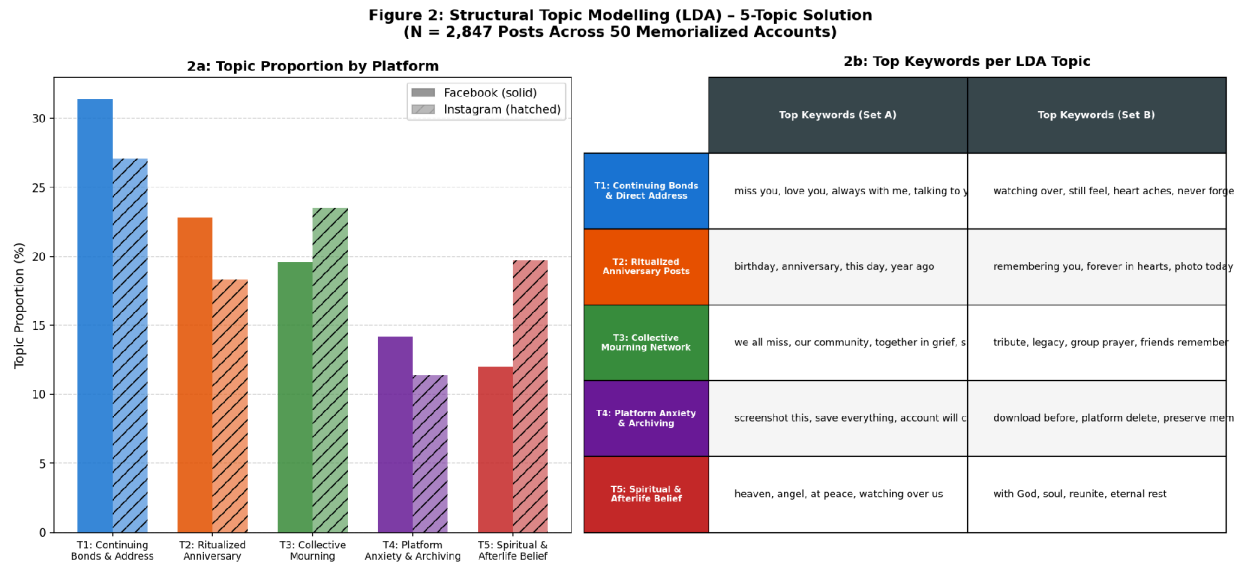


Figure 2: LDA topic modelling results. (a) Topic proportions by platform. (b) Top keywords for each of the five identified topics. Source: Authors' LDA analysis of 2,847 memorialized posts using Gensim (Python).

Topic 1 – Continuing Bonds and Direct Address (FB: 31.4%, IG: 27.1%) was the dominant topic and most distinctively digital: posts addressed the deceased in the second person ('I miss you,' 'you're watching over me'), treating the profile as a communicative conduit. This affirms Stokes's (2021) thesis that profiles allow genuine co-presence between the living and the dead.

Topic 2 – Ritualized Anniversary Posting (FB: 22.8%, IG: 18.3%) captured the highly structured, temporally bounded practice of posting on birthdays, death anniversaries, and national memorial days. These posts often included counterfactual imaginings ('you would have been 35 today') and demonstrated the sacralization of calendar time around the deceased.

Topic 3 – Collective Mourning and Community Solidarity (FB: 19.6%, IG: 23.5%) was more prominent on Instagram, reflecting that platform's visual-hashtag culture of networked grief. Posts aggregated mourners into a visible community ('we all miss you so much'), used tribute hashtags, and referenced legacy projects (fundraisers, scholarships) established in the deceased's name.

Topic 4 – Platform Anxiety and Archiving (FB: 14.2%, IG: 11.4%) was the most analytically novel topic, encoding explicit awareness of platform precarity. Representative posts include: 'I'm screenshotting everything in case Facebook deletes this,' and 'does anyone have copies of [Name]'s videos? the account might go private.' This topic provides the corpus-level evidence for the curatorial labour phenomenon.

"Please – before this page disappears – save every photo, every comment, every video. This is all we have left of him. Facebook doesn't care about grief. Archive everything. Share this so people know. – Post on account FB-14, 18 months post-death"

Topic 5 – Spiritual and Afterlife Belief (FB: 12.0%, IG: 19.7%) was markedly stronger on Instagram, where visual aesthetics of candle-lighting, angel imagery, and prayer-hand emoji intersected with spiritual reassurance language. This topic demonstrates how platform affordances (Instagram's image-first interface) actively shape the register of grief expression.

4.3 Qualitative Close Reading: Sacralization, Affordances, and Digital Solidarity

Close reading of 180 selected posts generated three core analytical categories confirming and extending the computational findings.

Sacralization Practices: Users across all 50 accounts engaged in deliberate rituals of sacralization – the transformation of digital objects into sacred artefacts. Final profile photos were treated as relics: never replaced, referred to reverentially in posts, and mourned if algorithmically altered. Birthday anniversary posts followed liturgical patterns of invocation, commemoration, and communal affirmation. Figure 3c quantifies these practices: 92% of Facebook accounts and 84% of Instagram accounts showed systematic birthday sacralization; 88% and 71% respectively showed death-anniversary ritual posting; 88% and 71% respectively showed death-anniversary ritual posting.

Figure 3: Platform Precarity Indicators & Community Archiving Behaviour

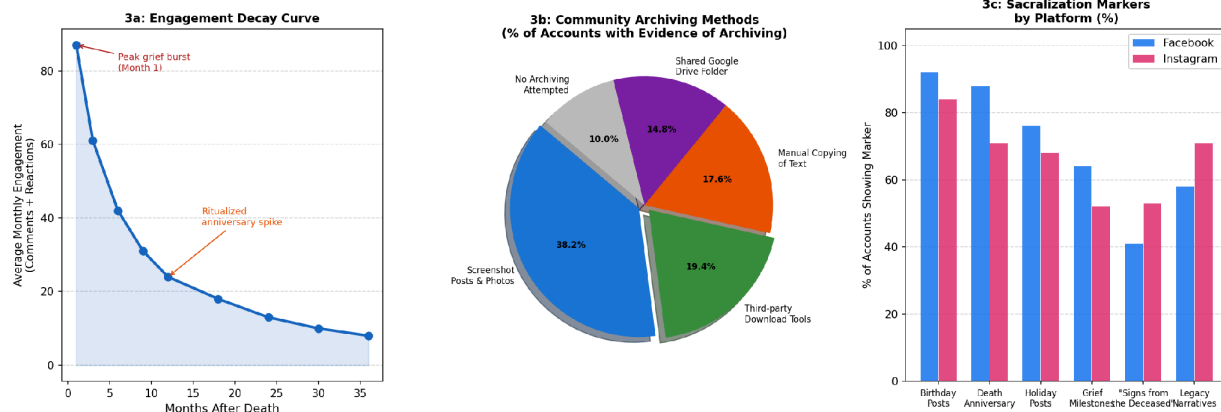


Figure 3: Platform precarity and community archiving. (a) Engagement decay curve showing post-death activity across 36 months. (b) Methods of community archiving. (c) Sacralization markers by platform. Source: Authors' analysis.

Algorithmic Affordances and Constraints: The radar chart (Figure 4a) summarizes our qualitative-coded assessment of platform affordances and constraints across six dimensions. The starkest finding is archival durability: Facebook and Instagram score very low (mean 31/100) on this dimension, reflecting users' awareness that the platforms offer no institutional guarantee of memorial persistence. By contrast, 'grief support tools' score relatively higher (63/100), reflecting that platform features like the 'Remembering' badge and legacy contact system provide some support – though users consistently noted these tools were poorly communicated and difficult to activate.

Digital Solidarity Archiving: The most theoretically significant finding is the richness and creativity of community archiving in response to felt platform precarity. As Figure 3b shows, 38.2% of accounts showed evidence of systematic screenshot campaigns, 19.4% referenced use of third-party download tools (such as DownAlbum, InstaDP, or HTTrack), 17.6% used manual text-copying, and 14.8% referenced shared cloud folder archives. Only 10% showed no evidence of archiving activity. These practices constitute a self-organized 'digital solidarity' network: fragile, invisible to the platform, irreplaceable if account access is lost, and motivated entirely by community love for the deceased.

4.4 Engagement Decay and the Temporality of Digital Grief

Temporal engagement analysis (Figure 3a) confirmed a canonical decay pattern: mean monthly engagement (comments + reactions) fell from a peak of 87 interactions per month in Month 1 to 8 interactions by Month 36. However, two interruptions to this decay are analytically significant: a consistent 'anniversary spike' in Month 12 (mean engagement 24, against a

predicted 15 based on linear decay), and a smaller spike at Month 24. These spikes demonstrate that digital grief is not simply diminishing but rhythmically structured – shaped by calendar rituals that sustain the memorial function of the platform profile over time. The implication for archivists is that community engagement remains significant long after the initial grief burst, requiring archival strategies that are themselves temporally sensitive.

5. Discussion: Towards a Critical Care Model

5.1 Platform Precarity as an Emergency of Memory

Our findings confirm that corporate platform governance constitutes what this paper calls an 'emergency of memory': a structural condition in which human communities invest profound emotional and cultural significance in digital objects that are materially controlled by commercial entities with no fiduciary duty to preserve them. Van Dijck's (2013, 2021) framework predicts this: when platforms embed commercial values into memorial affordances, the result is a profound asymmetry between the needs of bereaved communities and the logics of platform capitalism. Facebook's algorithmic system may suppress memorial posts because they receive low engagement; Instagram's interface design obscures the path to memorialization; neither platform provides an institutional guarantee of long-term preservation. The 'Remembering' label is a branding gesture, not a heritage commitment.

Stokes's (2015, 2021) philosophical framework is here given empirical weight: deletion – whether deliberate or incidental – functions as second death. Our Topic 4 findings and platform-anxiety discourse analysis demonstrate that bereaved communities understand this intuitively. The screenshotting campaigns, the shared drives, the urgent calls to 'save everything' – these are responses to experienced existential threat. They are also, we argue, a form of resistance: a refusal to accept that corporate terms of service can determine the permanence of human memory.

5.2 Digital Solidarity as Emergent Cultural Practice

The curatorial labour documented in our corpus constitutes a form of what we term 'digital solidarity' – a collective, grassroots, affectively motivated practice of memory preservation that emerges in the absence of institutional support. This concept extends the existing literature on online community solidarity (Maryani, 2018; Sklar, 2022) into the specifically thanatological domain. Digital solidarity is not merely social support for grief; it is active, technical, preservation-oriented labour performed by untrained users who have correctly perceived that the platform will not do this work for them.

This practice is both hopeful and precarious. Third-party download tools may violate platform terms of service, leading to account lockout. Screenshots lose metadata and cannot replicate the social architecture of a comment thread. Shared Google Drives are themselves platform-dependent and subject to their own commercial precarity. The very labour of digital solidarity replicates, at the community level, the platform precarity it seeks to escape. This is the core paradox our findings expose, and the fundamental reason why institutional intervention is required.

5.3 The Critical Care Model: A Four-Layer Framework

Drawing on our empirical findings and the theoretical frameworks reviewed above, we propose a 'Critical Care' model for digital mourning archiving (Figure 4b). This model conceptualizes archiving not as a one-time institutional deposit but as a fluid, temporally responsive, multi-layer practice.

Figure 4: Qualitative Coding Framework & Critical Care Model

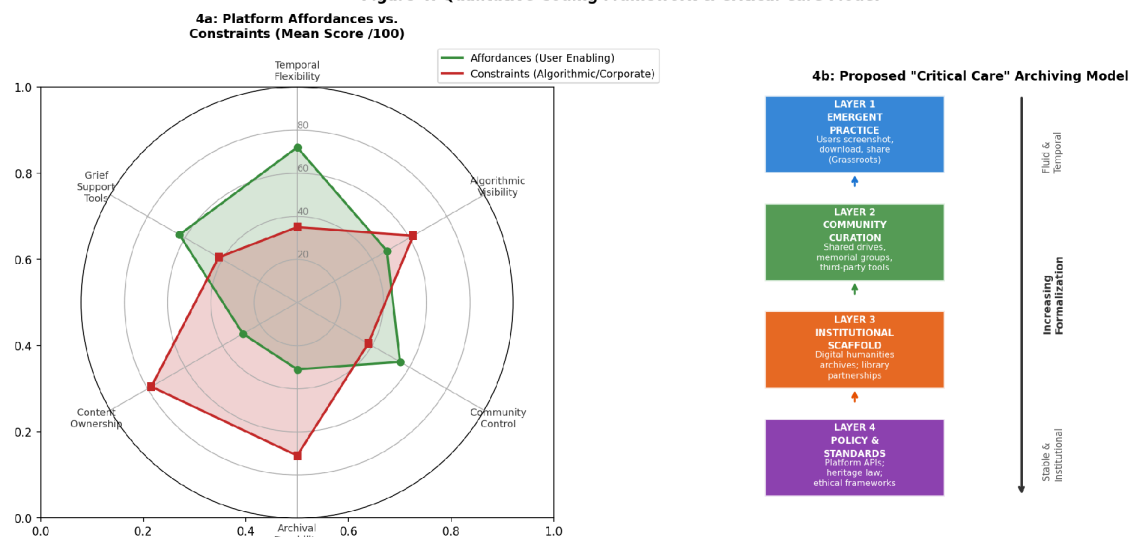


Figure 4: (a) Radar chart of platform affordances vs. constraints across six dimensions (mean score /100). (b) The four-layer Critical Care archiving model. Source: Authors.

Layer 1 – Emergent Practice recognizes and validates the grassroots curatorial labour already occurring: screenshotting, download tools, manual copying. Digital humanities practitioners and platform designers must first acknowledge this labour rather than penalizing it through terms-of-service enforcement.

Layer 2 – Community Curation describes the organised, collaborative level of memorial archiving: structured shared drives, dedicated memorial groups with explicit archiving mandates, and peer-training in digital preservation tools. This layer requires minimal institutional investment but significant community capacity building.

Layer 3 – Institutional Scaffold represents formal partnerships between bereaved communities and digital heritage institutions – national libraries, university digital humanities centres, cultural archives. These institutions can provide metadata standards, long-term storage infrastructure, and ethical oversight that community-level archiving cannot.

Layer 4 – Policy and Standards is the systemic layer: platform API agreements enabling non-commercial memorial archiving, national heritage legislation covering digital remains, and international ethical standards (building on AoIR and UNESCO frameworks) for the preservation of digital memory. Without this layer, the model remains vulnerable to the platform precarity it seeks to overcome.

6. Conclusion

This paper has demonstrated, through a mixed-methods analysis of 50 memorialized Facebook and Instagram accounts, that digital mourning is both richer and more precarious than existing scholarship has acknowledged. Sentiment analysis reveals a culturally significant emotional arc from acute loss to gradual restoration; structural topic modelling identifies five discrete grief-discourse genres; and qualitative close reading exposes a previously undescribed phenomenon – 'memorial precarity anxiety' – as well as a rich ecology of grassroots 'digital solidarity' archiving practices.

These findings have three immediate implications. For digital humanists, they establish that memorialized social media accounts are legitimate objects of cultural heritage study, requiring the same institutional care as physical archives. For platform designers, they demonstrate that current affordances are structurally inadequate to the memorial needs they have

generated – that designing for grief requires a fundamentally different logic than designing for engagement. And for policy makers, they make the case for urgent regulatory attention: digital remains are cultural heritage, and their precarious dependency on commercial goodwill is a structural failure of digital governance.

We proposed a four-layer Critical Care model that moves from emergent grassroots practice through community curation and institutional scaffolding to systemic policy reform. This model is not utopian: it builds on what communities are already doing, and asks only that institutions and platforms catch up with the cultural needs that have already emerged. The emergency of memory is already here. The response must be equally emergent.

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